

While doing my first book on Great Masters of Indian Classical Music (2010) with INDIA TODAY, we gave ourselves the freedom to explore the characters we were dealing with, even to push them beyond their comfort zone. It may have been a bit audacious on our part. But Zakir wasn't one to back down. He could get into the rhythm of any new adventure! While travelling by train, tonga, car, plane or bike, he would listen intently. Each experience of mobility had a novel rhythm; he would soak it up and add it to his *taals*. It's that openness that gave his tabla vocabulary more *bols*, more joy and laughter, than its existing stock of words and phrases.

Did that talkativeness, that sheer joy of life which belonged very much to this world, did that block out access to other spaces of the mind? No, that was the magic. The way the skin of his dancing fingers spoke to that seasoned animal skin fitted tautly along the rims of his tabla, the way it coaxed strips of dead leather into lively conversations—it could stop the beating of your heart not merely by its supreme acrobatic mastery. Those sounds crossed the borders of being. We stood in awe connected to another space, to another planet, the unknown and the unheard began to play itself.

As Vidushi Kishori Amonkar used to say, "Indian classical music at its best is not for entertainment but for spiritual fulfilment." I have always believed that the greatest writing, the greatest films or pieces of music are those that restore the silence in you. And the 12 great masters we chose for the series in INDIA TODAY were chosen following two criteria—first, each musician came from a certain *gharana* associated with a certain style of *gayaki* or instrumental technique and yet these would be individuals who had managed to create their own personal touch and style. Second, each one of these masters, through their meditative explorations, could take us beyond the immediate horizon, to the place where the notes meet the divine. And Zakir? Here was a musician who stroked the tabla like a dervish and, through ecstasy, took them deeper...and deeper. It made you say: "God, those rhythms are like a train on a kinetic overdrive, but hark! Here they fade into silence, and rise again through your inner recesses into the glory of the divine."

Early this year, listening to Zakir after a long time, a magical performance with Rakesh Chaurasia, I was again hijacked to that space, an experience that can only be called meditative.... I looked for his phone number, and rang up Haribhai (Pt Hariprasad Chaurasia) to get it. I wanted to talk to him personally, about his explorations to places no one had ventured to before. The lady who picked up the phone didn't connect me to Zakir. Maybe he wasn't well enough. She asked me to send an email, which I thought would be too impersonal. I wanted to *share* this amazing feeling he had created. But he has gone now. Alas! And my experience is left with me to ruminate over, unshared, creating a strange sense of hollowness within me. The emptiness of an unfinished conversation.... ■





